tenance alerts. Similarly, the domestic voice assistant is going to get more connected to the Internet of Things (all devices that connect with other devices over the internet), being able to control everything in a home from locks to cameras, geysers to fridges. "Smart wi-fi-enabled cameras and biometric locks will be standard features and so would be lights and air conditioning. The devices would be connected to the internet, making it easier to manage homes from mobile apps," says Agarwal.

THE DARK SIDE

There are concerns too. Primarily, for the youth who spend so much time with voice assistants. "Kids need to understand it is tech and not develop human-like attachment and emotions for them. There should be a disclaimer that you are talking to a computer program," says Abhishek Bhatnagar, founder & editor of @gadgetstouse.

RAJWANT RAWAT



"ASKING ALEXA FOR THINGS MAKES LIFE EASIER. THE BIGGEST WIN? CONTROLLING MY WATER PUMP REMOTELY. PLUS, FOR MUSIC, ALARMS, REMINDERS...I MISS HAVING HER AROUND WHEN I'M IN A PLACE WITHOUT ONE"

MANSI SINGH *29*
Founder's office employee in a private firm, Mumbai

Voice Assistant used: Alexa

HARDIK CHHABRA



"I USE GOOGLE ASSISTANT AND IT CHANGES THE VIBES OF THE HOUSE FROM QUIET TO MUSICAL. AT TIMES YOU FEEL YOU HAVE COMPANY EVEN IF YOU ARE BY YOURSELF"

RASHMI GANDHI *43*
Employed at Aspire Lifestyles, New Delhi

Voice Assistant used: Google Assistant

But privacy issues are the biggest worry. Even though some smart speakers can now be 'muted', how much of one's private life is getting compromised is an open question. And what happens if all the information we are 'willingly' keying in or speaking out loud to our devices gets hacked? From sexual preferences to personal identification details, and from school group chats to professional project notes—assistants begin to have complete access to our lives.

"Voice assistants are always listening for 'wake' words," says Agarwal. "While this always-on listening mode is required for quick responses by the assistant, it can make one feel uncomfortable. I have noticed some websites display contextual ads based on private conversations we were having among friends."

Whether smart assistants are a novelty use-for-a-few-months purchase or just the tip of the iceberg of greater control of lives when generative AI and voice technology are brought together remains to be seen. But it's an undeniable fact that human beings are increasingly opening their innermost selves to the smart assistants of their choice. ■